



Step-by-step: Sort datasets in spreadsheets

This reading outlines the steps the instructor performs in the following video, [Sort datasets in spreadsheets](#). In this video, the instructor demonstrates how to sort data in spreadsheets with the data menu.

Keep this step-by-step guide open as you watch the video. It can serve as a helpful reference tool if you need additional context or clarification while following the video steps. This is not a graded activity, but you can complete these steps to practice the skills demonstrated in the video.

What you'll need

If you'd like to access the spreadsheet the instructor uses in this video, click the link to the dataset to create a copy. If you don't have a Google account, you may download the data directly from the attachments below.

Link to movie data starter project: [Movie data starter project](#).

OR

Example 1: Sort a sheet with the menu

Use the menu to quickly and easily sort an entire sheet, keeping rows together.

1. Open the [Movie data starter project](#) spreadsheet.
2. Select cell B to highlight all of column B.
3. Select Data from the menu.
4. Select Sort sheet.
5. Select Sort sheet by column B (A to Z).
6. Notice that the movies in your spreadsheet are now arranged in chronological order based on the release date.

Note: In the video, the sorted results are not entirely correct as shown. While the release dates appear to be sorted in ascending order, many of the movie titles are also in alphabetical order. As a data analyst, you may suspect that this is too much of a coincidence and that something is not quite right with the data. In this example, the movie titles in column A may have been previously sorted alphabetically and the data wasn't restored to the original unsorted format.

Example 2: Sort data in a specific column with the menu

Use the menu to sort one column without affecting how the rest of the sheet is arranged. Each row in a table describes a single observation, so if you sort only one column you can introduce errors throughout your dataset. Use caution when using this option!

1. Select cell A to highlight all of column A.
2. Select Data from the menu.
3. Select Sort range.
4. Select Sort range by column A (A to Z).
5. Notice that the movie data across the rows is now jumbled because sorting a single column in a sheet doesn't keep data in a row together.

Note: As you've learned, each row in a table describes a single observation. Here, the values in Column A (movie titles) were sorted in A-to-Z order, but the rest of the sheet wasn't sorted. For example, before sorting by column A, *The Devil Inside* was listed as having a release date of 2012-01-06. After sorting only the movie titles in Column A in A-to-Z order, however, *The Devil Inside* is listed as having a release date of 2015-06-16. This is incorrect.